

QUIT INDIA MOVEMENT (1942)

The **Quit India Movement**, also known as the **August Revolution**, was launched in response to the **failure of the Cripps Mission (UPSC 2013)**. It called for immediate **British withdrawal** and initiated a **non-violent non-cooperation movement** against any possible Japanese invasion. The movement, endorsed by the **Congress Working Committee (CWC)** on **July 14, 1942**, in **Wardha**, differed from previous campaigns due to its **spontaneous mass participation**. It was a leaderless movement. [UPSC 2011]

- **Slogan:** The rallying cry was “**Quit India**” or “**Bharat Choro**”, symbolising a national call for liberation.
- **Public Militancy and Repression:** Characterised by **unprecedented public courage** and militancy, the movement faced severe repression. The British, prioritising their **war efforts**, imposed **draconian measures** and declared most political activities illegal, framing the movement as **revolutionary** and threatening to colonial rule.
- **Responsible Factors**
 - **Cripps Mission Failure (1942):** Highlighted British reluctance for progress, fueling self-determination demands.
 - **Inflation & Shortages:** Discontent from essential shortages; rumours of British scorched earth policies.
 - **British Setbacks:** Losses in Southeast Asia and Burma increased Japanese invasion fears.
 - **Economic Insecurity:** Bank runs, gold hoarding.
 - **Regional Impact:** Strong in **Eastern U.P.** and **Bihar**, less in **Madras**.
- **Wardha Meeting (July 1942) and the Quit India Movement**
 - **Quit India Resolution:** During the **Congress Working Committee (CWC)** meeting in Wardha, Gandhi was empowered to lead a **non-violent mass movement** for British withdrawal. This **Quit India Resolution**, proposed by **Jawaharlal Nehru** and seconded by **Sardar Patel**, was later ratified at the **All India Congress Committee meeting in Gowalia Tank, Bombay** on **August 8, 1942**.
 - **Gandhi’s Stance:** Gandhi, confident that the moment was opportune, expressed impatience to proceed with the struggle, even if Congress was hesitant. However, the Congress followed his lead, marking unity in the decision for mass action.
- **‘Kurnool Circular’ (July 29, 1942):** The Provincial Congress Committee in Andhra issued the ‘Kurnool Circular’, drafted by Kala Venkat Rao, and sent for CWC approval through Dr. Pattabhi Sitaramaiah. This document outlined strategic directives for the movement, though it was seized by police when the Kurnool Congress Office was raided.
- **The Quit India Resolution at Gowalia Tank (August 8, 1942) by AICC.** [UPSC 2021]

During the **Gowalia Tank** meeting, the Congress adopted the **Quit India Resolution**, which included the following demands and directives:

 1. **Immediate End to British Rule** in India.
 2. **Commitment of Free India** to resist fascism and imperialism.
 3. **Formation of a Provisional Government** post-British withdrawal.
 4. **Sanction of Civil Disobedience** against British rule.
- **Gandhi’s rallying cry, “Do or Die,”** underscored the movement’s intensity and urgency. Gandhi’s general instructions to different sections were:
 - Gandhi urged unity and nonviolent resistance.
 - **Hindus & Muslims:** Set aside religious differences for Indian unity.
 - **Government Servants:** Stay in service, pledge allegiance to Congress.
 - **Soldiers:** Avoid firing on fellow Indians.
 - **Students:** Leave studies if able to contribute.
 - **Peasants:** Withhold rent from pro-government zamindars.
 - **Princes:** Support masses, ally with anti-government rulers.
- **Spread of the Quit India Movement**
 - **Preparation & Initial Arrests (Aug 9, 1942):** Gandhi built momentum through civil disobedience, propaganda. British preemptively arrested Congress leaders, declared Congress unlawful under **Criminal Law Amendment Act; Rule 56 of Defence of India Rules** banned public meetings.

- **Aruna Asaf Ali:** Led the movement, hoisted the flag at the **Congress session** on August 9.
- **Public Rampage & Sabotage:** Acts of defiance—hoisting flags, facing arrest. **Sabotage** in **U.P., Bihar:** bridges, railway tracks, telegraph lines.
- **Student & Worker Participation:** Strikes in **Ahmedabad, Bombay, Jamshedpur, Poona;** students led strikes, circulated illegal **news sheets**.
- **Underground Activity:** Leadership went underground, coordinated activities across **Bombay, Poona, Satara, Gujarat, Bihar, Delhi**. **Usha Mehta's Radio:** Established underground radio, maintained morale, evaded detection. [UPSC 2011]
- **Key Figures:** **Rammanohar Lohia, Jayaprakash Narayan, Aruna Asaf Ali, Usha Mehta, Biju Patnaik, Chhotubhai Puranik, Achyut Patwardhan, Sucheta Kripalani, R.P. Goenka.**

Parallel Governments during Quit India Movement

Parallel Government	Leader	Activities
Ballia (August 1942)	Chittu Pandey	Secured the release of numerous Congress leaders; emerged for a week as a parallel government.
Tamluk (Dec 1942 - Sep 1944) - Midnapore	Jatiya Sarkar	Engaged in cyclone relief efforts, allocated grants to schools, provided paddy from the affluent to the needy, organised Vidyut Vahinis .
Satara (Mid-1943 - 1945) - "Prati Sarkar"	Y.B.Chavan, Nana Patil, etc.	Established village libraries, created Nyayadan Mandals, conducted prohibition campaigns, and arranged 'Gandhi marriages'; known as "Prati Sarkar."

Mass Participation in the Quit India Movement

Aspect	Details
Youth	● Students, especially from schools and colleges, played a prominent role.
Women	● Women, particularly school and college girls, are actively engaged. ● Notable figures included Aruna Asaf Ali, Sucheta Kripalani, and Usha Mehta.
Workers	● Strikes occurred in cities like Ahmedabad, Bombay, Jamshedpur, Ahmednagar, and Poona. The labour class, however, did not broadly engage.
Peasants	● Peasants from various strata were central to the movement. ● Attacks were directed at symbols of authority, with no anti-zamindar violence reported.
Government Officials	● Lower-level government officials, including police, participated, indicating a decline in loyalty to the British government.
Muslims	● Muslims provided shelter to underground activists, with no communal clashes occurring during the movement.
Communists	● The Communist Party refrained from participation, aligning instead with the British war effort following the Nazi attack on Russia.
Muslim League	● The Muslim League opposed the movement, expressing concerns over potential minority oppression if the British withdrew.
Hindu Mahasabha	● The Hindu Mahasabha boycotted the movement, reflecting its distinct political stance.
Princely States	● Princely states exhibited a subdued response to the movement, showing limited engagement.

Government's Response to the Quit India Movement

- **August 9, 1942:** All top Congress leaders were arrested and transported to undisclosed locations.
- The **Congress Working Committee, All India Congress Committee, and Provincial Congress Committees** were declared unlawful under the **Criminal Law Amendment Act of 1908**.

- Martial law was not implemented, but harsh measures were taken: **baton charges, tear gas, and gunfire** were used on crowds.
- The **death toll** was estimated at around **10,000**.
- **Press freedom** was suppressed, and the **military took control** in numerous cities, with the police and secret service exercising significant authority.
- Defiant villages faced heavy fines and **mass floggings** as punishment.

Gandhi's Fast (February 1943)

- **Reason:** Gandhi undertook a fast in response to the British government's demand to condemn violence, but he focused his protest against the state's own use of force.
- **Public Reaction:** The fast garnered widespread public support, leading to **domestic and international protests** such as hartals, demonstrations, and strikes.
- **Solidarity:** Three members of the Viceroy's Executive Council resigned in protest.
- **Outcomes:** Boosted **public morale. Strengthened anti-British sentiments.** Allowed for a surge in **political activity.** Exposed the government's **authoritarian actions.**

Pakistan Day (March 23, 1943): On March 23, 1943, Pakistan Day was observed, marking a significant milestone in the demand for a separate state for Muslims.

THE FAMINE OF 1943

- **Worst-hit Regions:** Southwestern Bengal, including **Tamluk-Contai-Diamond Harbour, Dacca, Faridpur, Tippera, and Noakhali.**
- **Death Toll:** Approximately **1.5 to 3 million** people died due to starvation, malnutrition, and epidemics (malaria, cholera, and smallpox).

Causes: Supplies were redirected to feed the British Army. **Disruption of Rice Imports:** Imports from **Burma and Southeast Asia** were halted. **Mismanagement and Profiteering:** The crisis worsened due to **gross mismanagement** and profiteering. Rationing was introduced late and limited to major cities, leaving rural areas without essential support.

INDIVIDUAL EFFORTS TO RESOLVE CONSTITUTIONAL CRISIS

- **Rajagopalachari Formula (1944)**
Initiative: In 1944, C. Rajagopalachari (CR), a senior Congress leader, proposed a plan, later known as the **Rajagopalachari Formula**, aimed at bridging the Congress-League divide. The formula tacitly acknowledged the League's demand for Pakistan.
 - **Support:** Gandhi endorsed the plan, signalling Congress's willingness to cooperate.

Key Points of the Rajagopalachari Formula

- **Independence:** The Muslim League would endorse the Congress's demand for independence.
- **Provisional Government:** The League would collaborate with Congress to establish a provisional central government.
- **Plebiscite:** After World War II, a **plebiscite** would allow the people in **Muslim-majority areas** in North-West and North-East India to decide on forming a separate sovereign state.
- **Post-Partition Agreement:** If partition was agreed upon, there would be a **joint agreement** to safeguard defence, commerce, and communications between the new entities.
- **Voluntary Population Transfer:** Any population transfer would be **voluntary**.
- **British Handover:** The formula's implementation depends on **Britain transferring full powers** to India.
- **Jinnah's Position: Opposition**
 - Demanded Congress's acceptance of the **two-nation theory**.
 - Proposed that only **Muslims** in North-West and North-East India, rather than the entire population, participate in the plebiscite.
 - Opposed the idea of a **common centre** for defence and governance.
- **Opposition from Hindu Leaders:** Hindu leaders, particularly **Vir Savarkar**, condemned the Rajagopalachari Plan, viewing it as an acceptance of the League's demand for Pakistan.
- **Gandhi-Jinnah Parleys (1944)**
 After Gandhi's release on May 5, 1944, he proposed negotiations with Jinnah based on the Rajagopalachari (CR) Formula. Jinnah rejected it, accusing Rajagopalachari of "mutilating" the original Lahore Resolution. Gandhi opposed the two-nation theory, advocating for Indian independence for all. Jinnah insisted on Muslims' right to self-determination as a separate nation. Key issues included a plebiscite (rejected by the League) and a common centre for **defence, commerce, and communications.** The talks collapsed after two weeks due to deep ideological differences.
- **Desai-Liaquat Pact (1945)**
 - **Objective:** To establish a provisional arrangement for governance at the centre and ease the tension between Congress and the Muslim League.
 - **Key Provisions of the Pact**
 - ◆ **Equal Representation:** Proposed an **equal number of representatives** from Congress and the Muslim League in the central legislature for the interim government.

- ♦ **Minority Representation:** Reserved **20% of seats** for minorities.
- ♦ **Outcome:** No final agreement was reached, but the pact's emphasis on equal representation indicated a potential shift towards parity between Congress and the League. The failure of the pact, however, underscored the persistent divide in the two parties' visions for India's future.

WAVELL PLAN (1945)

Post-Europe war, **Churchill's Conservative government** sought a solution for India's future. **Lord Wavell**, Viceroy, began negotiations; Congress were released (June 1945) for talks.

- **Britain's Interest:**
 - **British Elections:** Conservatives wanted to demonstrate commitment to India's constitutional resolution.
 - **War Efforts:** Allied forces urged more Indian support for the ongoing war.
 - **Strategic Redirection:** Aimed at steering Indian efforts in a way beneficial to Britain.
- **Key Features of Wavell Plan:**
 - **Indian Majority:** All executive council members, except **Governor-General** and **Commander-in-Chief**, would be Indian.
 - **Equal Representation:** Caste Hindus and Muslims would have equal representation.
 - **Interim Government:** Under **1935 Government of India Act** framework.
 - **Governor-General's Veto:** Veto power retained but exercised on ministerial advice.
 - **Party Representation:** Joint nominations or separate lists for council members.
 - **Post-War Constitution:** Further discussions on a new constitution would follow after the war.

SHIMLA CONFERENCE (JUNE 1945)

- **Objective:** To finalise the **Wavell Plan**, focusing on self-governance for India.
- **Positions of Muslim League:**
 - **Nomination Control:** Demanded Muslim council members be League nominees to avoid minority influence from Congress.
 - **Veto Power:** Sought a two-thirds majority veto for decisions affecting Muslim interests.
- **Positions of Congress:**
 - **Representation of All Communities:** Opposed the plan, seeing it as an effort to limit Congress to caste Hindus.
 - **Broad-Based Nominations:** Insisted on the right to nominate members from all communities.

Breakdown of Talks:

- **Wavell's Mistake:** Declared talks a failure, inadvertently giving the **Muslim League** de facto veto power in council matters.
- **Impact:** Strengthened **Jinnah's influence** and the League's position, as seen in the **1945-46 elections**, highlighting divisions between Congress and the League.

SUBHASH CHANDRA BOSE

Early Life and Education

- **Birth:** January 23, 1897, in **Cuttack, Orissa**.
- **Family Background:** Born into a well-educated family; father **Janakinath Bose** was a prominent lawyer, and his brother, **Sarat Chandra Bose**, was a notable freedom fighter.
- **Education:** An outstanding student, he completed his schooling in **Cuttack** and **Calcutta**, graduating with honours in **philosophy** from **Cambridge University** in **1919**.

Role in the Indian Independence Movement

- **Involvement with INC:** Joined the **Indian National Congress (INC)**, advocating for immediate independence and opposing **Mahatma Gandhi's** strategy of **non-violence**.
- **INC Presidency:** Elected **President** of the INC in **1938** and **1939**, where he promoted more radical actions and sought to escalate the struggle against British rule.
- **Formation of Forward Bloc:** Resigned from the INC in **1939** due to ideological conflicts, subsequently founding the **Forward Bloc** to advocate for a more aggressive stance against British colonialism.

Ideology and Vision: Bose advocated for **complete independence**, anti-imperialism, and a **socialist, secular India**. He supported **armed resistance** against British rule and sought alliances with **Germany** and **Japan** during WWII. Escaping house arrest in **1941**, Bose led the **INA** and established **Azad Hind Radio**. He died mysteriously in a **1945 plane crash**, with his slogan, "**Give me blood, I'll give you freedom**", enduring as a symbol of resistance.

Azad Hind Fauj (Indian National Army)

- **Formation:** Initially organised by **Captain Indian Army** list July 1941. **Mohan Singh** and **Rash Behari Bose** in **Japan** to combat British rule with **Axis support**.
- **Provisional Government:** Declared the **Azad Hind government** on **October 21, 1943**, in **Singapore**, aiming to rally Indians for independence.

Rash Behari Bose (1886–1945)

- **Early Life & Activism:** Fled to **Japan** in **1915** after revolutionary activities in India. Founded the **Indian Club** in Tokyo, advocating for independence and opposing Western imperialism.
- **Indian Independence League:** Established **1942**, unifying efforts for freedom. In **1943**, handed over INA leadership to **Subhas Chandra Bose** (Supreme Commander).
- **Health & Death:** Died on **January 21, 1945** after a lung collapse in **February 1944**.

Ras Behari Ghosh (1845–1921)

- **Early Life & Education:** Born in **Bengal Presidency**, educated at **University of London**, law degree.
- **Political Career:** Congress President **1907 & 1908**, advocated for **self-governance** and **constitutional reforms**. Played key role in **Surat Split (1907)**.
- **Social Reforms:** Promoted **women's education** and **social upliftment** for lower castes.
- **Legacy:** Intellectual contributions, shaping Congress ideology, and laying the foundation for India's freedom struggle.

Note: Both are different.

INDIAN NATIONAL ARMY (INA): FORMATION AND ACTIVITIES

- **Initiation by Mohan Singh:** In **World War II**, Indian officer **Mohan Singh** refused to join **British** forces in **Malaya**. He sought **Japanese support** to recruit **Indian prisoners of war (POWs)**, successfully forming an army.
- **Recruitment Success:** After the fall of **Singapore**, Singh enlisted about **40,000 men** by the end of **1942**, establishing the INA as a response to the potential **Japanese occupation** of India.
- **Bose's Arrival and Assumption of Command:** Subhas Chandra Bose arrived in **Singapore** in **July 1943** and took control of the INA. He established the **Provisional Government for Free India** on **October 21, 1943**, appointing key members like **H.C. Chatterjee** (Finance) and **Lakshmi Swaminathan** (Women's Department).
- **Declaration of War:** The provisional government declared war on **Britain** and the **United States**, gaining recognition from **Axis powers** and forming the **Rani Jhansi Regiment**, a dedicated women's unit.
- **INA Headquarters:** Moved to **Rangoon** (**January 1944**), rallying recruits with "**Chalo Delhi!**"
- **Andaman & Nicobar:** Given to INA by Japan on **November 6, 1943**, renamed **Shahid Dweep**, **Swaraj Dweep**.
- **Address to Gandhi:** **July 6, 1944**, Bose addressed Gandhi as "**Father of the Nation**" for blessings.

- **Imphal Campaign:** INA battalion under **Shah Nawaz**, faced discrimination, shortages, demoralisation.
- **Crossing into India:** The INA crossed the **Burma border** into India on **March 18, 1944**, advancing toward **Kohima** and **Imphal**.
- **INA Flag Hoisting:** **Colonel Malik** raised the INA flag at **Moirang, Manipur**, on **April 14, 1944**, marking a significant moment in the struggle for independence.
- **Military Administration:** The INA managed military administration at Moirang for **three months** until **Allied forces** reclaimed the territory, leading to the INA's withdrawal on **July 18, 1944**.
- **Japanese Surrender:** Following Japan's surrender on **August 15, 1945**, the INA also surrendered.
- **Bose's Mysterious Death:** Subhas Bose reportedly died in an air crash on **August 18, 1945**, in **Taipei, Taiwan**.
- **Post-War Events:** INA prisoners of war faced **court-martial** upon returning to India, prompting a strong movement for their defence and elevating the issue of Indian independence on the global stage.

POST-WAR NATIONAL SCENARIO

Change in Government's Attitude (June - September 1945)

- **Lifting of the Ban:** In June 1945, the government **lifted the ban** on Congress and released its leaders.
- **Failure of Wavell Plan:** The **Wavell Plan** failed to resolve the **constitutional deadlock**.
- **Labour Party Ascendancy:** In July 1945, the **Labour Party** took power in Britain, with **Clement Attlee** as Prime Minister and **Pethick Lawrence** as Secretary of State for India.
- **Elections Announced:** Elections for **central and provincial assemblies** were announced in August 1945, followed by the plan to convene a **constituent assembly** in September, aligning with the principles of the **Cripps Offer**.

Factors Responsible for Change in Government Attitude Post-War

- **Global Power Shift:** UK's decline, rise of **USA** and **USSR**, supporting India's independence.
- **Increased Sympathy:** The Labour government was more sympathetic towards Indian demands.
- **Resource Strain:** The UK's economic struggles, owing **£1.2 billion** to India by **1945**.
- **Anti-Imperialist Sentiment:** Resistance to colonial rule in **Vietnam** and **Indonesia**.
- **Fear of Revolt:** Threat of agrarian uprisings and disaffection among army and INA.
- **Inevitability of Elections:** Post-war elections became unavoidable, prompting British retreat.

INA TRIALS

At the **September 1945** Congress session in **Bombay**, a strong resolution endorsed the INA cause. Legal defence for INA prisoners was coordinated by leaders including **Bhulabhai Desai**, **Tej Bahadur Sapru**, **Kailash Nath Katju**, **Jawaharlal Nehru**, and **Asaf Ali**. The **INA Relief and Enquiry Committee** provided monetary and food assistance, as well as employment support for affected individuals. Organised efforts for **fund collection** were implemented.

The INA Agitation: A Landmark Movement

- **Intensified Campaign:** The movement gained widespread support through press coverage, pamphlets, public meetings, and editorials.
- **INA Day (November 12, 1945) & INA Week (November 5-11, 1945):** Celebrated across India.
- **Nationwide Participation:** Involved social groups and political parties from cities like **Delhi**, **Bombay**, **Calcutta**, and regions like **Coorg**, **Balochistan**, and **Assam**.
- **Cross-sector Support:** Film stars, municipal committees, and expatriates contributed.
- **Mass Activities:** Included shop closures, student meetings, kisan conferences, and demands for prisoner release.
- **Broad Support:** Congress, **Muslim League**, **Communist Party**, **Akalis**, **Hindu Mahasabha**, and even loyalist strongholds supported the cause.

Central Themes and Political Significance

- The movement questioned Britain's right to adjudicate Indian matters, framing the INA issue as an increasingly **"Indian versus British"** narrative.
- Public trials for INA prisoners began, with the first trial at the **Red Fort** in **November 1945**, involving leaders **Prem Kumar Sehgal**, **Shah Nawaz Khan**, and **Gurbaksh Singh Dhillon**, symbolising unity among Indians. [UPSC 2021]
- The deployment of Indian Army units to reinforce **French** and **Dutch** colonial rule in **Vietnam** and **Indonesia** heightened anti-imperialist sentiments among urban populations and the military.

THREE UPSURGES (WINTER OF 1945-46)

In the winter of 1945-46, heightened nationalist sentiment during the **INA trials** led to significant confrontations with authorities, marked by three key upsurges:

- **November 21, 1945:** Protest in **Calcutta** over INA trials.
- **February 11, 1946:** Demonstrations in **Calcutta** against the seven-year sentence for INA officer **Rashid Ali**.
- **February 18, 1946:** **Bombay Naval Strike** initiated by Royal Indian Navy ratings.

Three-Stage Pattern of the Upsurges

- **Stage I: Defiance of Authority**
 - **November 21, 1945:** Students, including Forward Bloc and SFI activists, protested at **Dalhousie Square**. They faced police lathi charges, retaliated with stones, resulting in two deaths.
 - **February 11, 1946:** Muslim League students protested **Rashid Ali's** sentence, defying **Section 144** and facing further arrests and lathi charges.
 - **February 18, 1946:** Around **1100 RIN ratings** from **HMIS Talwar** struck against racial discrimination and poor treatment, raising the **tricolour**, crescent, and hammer-and-sickle flags.
- **Stage II: Citywide Participation**
 - **Calcutta and Bombay** faced near paralysis from widespread anti-British sentiment, leading to numerous strikes and attacks on police, shops, and transport hubs.
- **Stage III: National Solidarity**
 - Students organised boycotts and hartals, sparking sympathetic strikes in military establishments across India. The **Royal Indian Air Force** also joined the protests.
 - On **February 23**, the ratings surrendered after assurances from **Patel** and **Jinnah** against victimisation.

NAVAL MUTINY: THE FINAL STRAW FOR BRITISH COLONIALISM

The **Royal Indian Navy Mutiny** in February 1946 marked a pivotal moment in India's independence struggle. Sailors protested poor conditions and racial discrimination, seeking independence.

The **mutiny** gained widespread support from the **Indian populace**, political leaders, and military factions, including the **Royal Indian Air Force**. It exposed **British vulnerability** and attracted **international pressure**, particularly from the **U.S.** and **Soviet Union**, urging **independence**. The mutiny fostered **unity** between the **Congress** and **Muslim League** and highlighted the impracticality of continued British rule, accelerating the **transfer of power**.

Evaluation of Impact

- **Militant Spirit:** The upsurges, including the RIN revolt, symbolised the looming end of British rule.
- **British Concessions:**
 - Dec 1, 1946: Trials limited to serious offences.
 - Jan 1947: Pardons for initial INA prisoners.
 - Feb 1947: Withdrawal of Indian soldiers from Indo-China/Indonesia.
 - Finalisation of Cabinet Mission and parliamentary delegation to India.
- **Limited Participation:** Mainly militant groups; urban-focused; British repression mechanisms remained largely effective.

Congress Strategy

- **Leftist Perspective:** Concern over loss of control, prioritising discipline in an independent India.
- **Uprisings Context:** Viewed as extensions of earlier nationalist movements; Congress refrained from endorsing violent uprisings.
- **Negotiation Focus:** Congress favoured negotiations, Gandhi opposed mutiny, urging resolution through established leadership.

ELECTION RESULTS (1945–1946)

Congress Performance

- Secured **91%** of non-Muslim votes.
- Won **57 out of 102** seats in the Central Assembly.
- Achieved majorities in most provinces, except **Bengal, Sindh, and Punjab**; notably held majorities in **NWFP and Assam**.

Muslim League Performance

- Garnered **86.6%** of Muslim votes and all **30** reserved seats in the Central Assembly.
- Secured majorities in **Bengal and Sindh**, solidifying its position as the dominant party among Muslims.

In **Punjab**, a coalition led by **Khizr Hayat Khan** included Unionists, Congress, and Akalis.

Key Features of Elections

- Elections exhibited **communal voting** due to separate electorates.
- **Limited Franchise:** Less than **10%** of the population could vote for provinces, and under **1%** for the Central Assembly.

CABINET MISSION

In February 1946, the **Attlee government** sent a high-powered **Cabinet Mission** to negotiate the **peaceful transfer of power** to India.

- **Members:** **Pethick Lawrence** (Chairman and Secretary of State for India), **Stafford Cripps** (President of the Board of Trade), and **A.V. Alexander** (First Lord of Admiralty).
- **Goal:** To set the framework for British withdrawal and future relations, emphasising the rights of minorities while preventing their veto on majority progress.
- The **Cabinet Mission** arrived in **Delhi** on **March 24, 1946**.
- **Held discussions on:**
 - Formation of an **interim government**.
 - **Constitutional framework** for India.
- **Outcome:** No consensus between **Congress** and **Muslim League** on unity or partition, prompting the mission to propose its **constitutional plan** in **May 1946**. **Rejection of Full-Fledged Pakistan**

Reasons for rejection:

- **Non-Muslim populations:** 38% in the North-West and 48% in the North-East.
- **Communal self-determination:** Risk of separating **Hindu-majority Bengal** and **Sikh/Hindu-majority Punjab**.
- Disruption of **regional ties** and military security risks.

Grouping of Provinces

- **Group A: Hindu-majority provinces** (Madras, Bombay, Central Provinces, United Provinces, Bihar, Orissa).
- **Group B: Muslim-majority provinces** (Punjab, North-West Frontier Province, Sindh).
- **Group C: Muslim-majority provinces** (Bengal, Assam).

Differing Views on Grouping Clause

- **Congress:** Preferred **optional grouping** and feared it would pave the way for **Pakistan**. Opposed **removal of veto power**.
- **Muslim League:** Insisted on **compulsory grouping** as a step towards **Pakistan**.

Federal Structure and Constituent Assembly

- Proposed a **three-tier government** (provincial, sectional, and union levels).
- The **Constituent Assembly** of **389 members**: 292 from provincial assemblies, 93 from princely states, and 4 from chief commissioner's provinces.
- **Central authority** to control **defence, communication, and external affairs**; provinces to have **autonomy** over other matters.

Communal Representation and Flexibility

- **Communal issues** in the central legislature to be decided by a simple majority of both communities present.
- Provinces could **exit their groups** after elections, and an **interim government** would form from the **Constituent Assembly**.

Objections to the Cabinet Mission Plan

- **Congress Objections:** Opposed **mandatory grouping** of provinces like **North-West Frontier Province (NWFP)** and **Assam**. Disagreed with the absence of **elected representatives** from princely states.
- **Muslim League Objections:** Insisted on **compulsory grouping** as a step towards **Pakistan**. Expected to be invited to form the **interim government** after Congress's rejection.

Acceptance and Rejection of the Plan

- **Muslim League** accepted the plan on **June 6, 1946**.
- **Congress** accepted on **June 24, 1946**.
- **Provincial Elections** held in **July 1946** for the **Constituent Assembly**.
- **Nehru's Statement (July 10, 1946):** Suggested that grouping might not be necessary due to objections from **NWFP and Assam**.

Muslim League Withdrawal and Direct Action

- On **July 29, 1946**, the **Muslim League** withdrew its acceptance and called for “**direct action**” from **August 16, 1946**, demanding **Pakistan**.
- Consequences:** Violent **communal riots** broke out, notably in **Calcutta, Bombay, Noakhali, Bihar, and Garhmukteshwar**, resulting in **thousands of deaths**.

Note: Members of the Constituent Assembly from the Provinces were elected by the Provincial Legislative Assemblies. [UPSC 2013]

THE INTERIM GOVERNMENT

The Interim Government

- Formation:** A Congress-led Interim Government, headed by **Jawaharlal Nehru**, was inaugurated on **September 2, 1946**.
- Nehru's Position:** Nehru maintained Congress's opposition to compulsory grouping.
- Functionality:** Despite being termed an “Interim Government”, it primarily functioned as an extension of the former viceroy's executive authority.
- Cabinet Dynamics:** In a final cabinet meeting in **March 1947**, Wavell overruled ministers on key decisions, including the release of **INA** prisoners.

Inclusion of the Muslim League

- Integration:** Wavell included the Muslim League in the Interim Government on **October 26, 1946**, despite the League's continued advocacy for ‘direct action’ and its rejection of both long-term and short-term Cabinet Mission plans.
- Boycott of Assembly:** The League boycotted the first meeting of the **Constituent Assembly** on **December 9, 1946**.
- Assembly Activities:** The Assembly primarily focused on passing the ‘**Objectives Resolution**’, drafted by Nehru, outlining the ideals of an independent sovereign republic.

Obstructionist Approach and Ulterior Motives of the League

- The League adopted an obstructionist approach, indicating ulterior motives during a critical phase of governance. The League refused to attend informal cabinet meetings, contesting decisions and appointments made by Congress members. As the finance minister, Liaquat Ali Khan imposed restrictions that hindered the effective functioning of other ministries. The League aimed to promote the cause of Pakistan, viewing its participation in the government as a continuation of the civil war through alternative means.
- Congress Demands:** Congress consistently pressed the British to influence the League's actions or encourage its withdrawal from the Interim Government. In **February**

1947, nine Congress cabinet members wrote to the viceroy, demanding the resignation of League members and threatening to withdraw their own nominees. The situation escalated when the League called for the dissolution of the Constituent Assembly, indicating a potential crisis ahead.

Ministers of the Interim Government (September 2, 1946 – August 15, 1947)

Name	Ministry
Jawaharlal Nehru	- Vice President - Executive Council - External Affairs - Commonwealth Relations
Vallabhbhai Patel	- Home - Information and Broadcasting - Baldev Singh
Baldev Singh	- Defence - Dr. John Mathai for Industries and Supplies
C. Rajagopalachari	Education
C.H. Bhabha	Work Mines and Power
Rajendra Prasad	Agriculture and Food
Jagjivan Ram	Labour
Asaf Ali	Railway
Muslim League Members	
Liaquat Ali Khan	Finance
Ibrahim Ismail Chundrigar	Commerce
Abdur Rab Nishtar	Communications
Ghazanfar Ali Khan	Health
Jogendra Nath Mandal	Law

WAVELL'S 'BREAKDOWN PLAN'

In May 1946, Lord Wavell proposed the **Breakdown Plan** to the Cabinet Mission, aiming for a compromise between “repression” and “scuttle.” Key aspects included:

- Withdrawal of British Forces:** The British Army and officials would retreat to Muslim provinces in North-West and North-East India.

- **Transfer of Power:** Authority over the rest of India would be handed to the Congress.
- **Recognition of Reality:** Acknowledgment that suppressing a Congress-led rebellion was increasingly untenable.
- **Desire for Partition:** Some British officials sought to create a division similar to “Northern Ireland” within Pakistan.

INDEPENDENCE WITH PARTITION

- From an **imperialist standpoint**, Britain viewed independence as fulfilling its mission to facilitate Indian self-government. **Partition** was perceived as a consequence of the **Hindu-Muslim divide** and the failure to achieve consensus on power transfer.
- A more radical view suggests that independence resulted from **mass actions** in 1946-47, where **Communists** emerged as leaders. However, bourgeois leaders in Congress, fearing a **revolutionary upsurge**, opted for negotiation with the imperialists, leading to a transfer of power that compromised national unity.
- The **Hindu Mahasabha** explored establishing a separate **Hindu province** in West Bengal.
- **Attlee’s Statement (Feb 20, 1947):** On February 20, 1947, Attlee announced that **British rule in India would end by June 30, 1948**, regardless of a constitutional agreement. Power could be transferred either to a central authority or directly to provincial governments, especially in Muslim-majority areas.
 - British responsibilities over princely states would also end without a successor government, hinting at partition, similar to the Cripps Offer. This decision aimed to resolve political deadlock, demonstrate British sincerity, and acknowledge Britain’s declining control, as noted by Lord Wavell.
 - The announcement triggered violence in Punjab, led to the collapse of Khizr Hayat Khan’s coalition, and pushed Congress to accept partition, while the Muslim League saw it as validation of its goals.
- On **March 10, 1947**, **Jawaharlal Nehru** suggested that the **Cabinet Mission’s** implementation was the best solution, with the partition of Punjab and Bengal as the only viable alternative.
- By **April 1947**, **Congress President J.B. Kriplani** expressed a willingness to accept Pakistan to avoid conflict, contingent on a fair partition of Bengal and Punjab.

Mountbatten as the Viceroy

As Viceroy, **Mountbatten (12, Feb 1947 to 15, Aug 1947)** showed greater decisiveness than his predecessors, benefiting

from a delegation of powers for on-the-spot decisions. He aimed to explore options for unity or division until **October 1947**. However, he quickly recognized the futility of the **Cabinet Mission Plan**, with **Jinnah** adamant about establishing a **sovereign state**.

- **Mountbatten Plan (June 3, 1947):** Freedom with partition. One major innovation (actually suggested by V.P. Menon) was the immediate transfer of power on the basis of grant of dominion status (with a right of secession), thus obviating the need to wait for an agreement in the constituent assembly on a new political structure.
- Main points the plan were:
 - Legislative Assemblies of **Punjab** and **Bengal** would vote for partition into separate Hindu and Muslim groups. A simple majority in either group would result in the partition of these provinces.
 - In the case of partition, two dominions (**India** and **Pakistan**) and two constituent assemblies would be created.
 - **Sindh** would make its own decision regarding partition.
 - **Referendums** in **NWFP** and the **Sylhet district** of Bengal would determine the fate of these areas.
- **Congress Concessions:** The Congress conceded the demand for a unified India while securing other demands, including:
 - **Princely states** would not be independent but would join either India or Pakistan.
 - Independence for Bengal was ruled out.
 - Accession of **Hyderabad** to Pakistan was ruled out (Mountbatten supported Congress on this).
 - Freedom was set for **August 15, 1947**.
 - A boundary commission would be set up if partition was to be effected.

Reasoning Behind the Early Date: The decision to set the transfer of power for **August 15, 1947**, was motivated by Britain’s desire to:

- Secure Congress’ acceptance of dominion status.
 - Evade responsibility for the escalating communal tensions.
- **Reactions to the Mountbatten Plan**
 - **Gandhi’s Response:** Mahatma **Gandhi** expressed deep distress at the partition and urged people to resist acceptance of the plan, emphasising that it contradicted the unity fostered during the freedom movement.
 - **Azad’s Opposition:** **Maulana Abul Kalam Azad** vehemently opposed the Congress leadership’s acquiescence to the plan, viewing it as a capitulation to power.

- **Concessions to Muslim League**
 - The **League's** demand for Pakistan was conceded, and the Congress's position on unity was considered to minimise the size of Pakistan.
- **Congress reason for Acceptance of Dominion Status & Partition**
 - **Continuity in Administration:** It allowed for continuity within the bureaucracy and military, crucial for governance.
 - **British Perspective:** For Britain, granting dominion status was a way to maintain India's connection to the **Commonwealth**, given India's economic strength and strategic importance.
 - **Failure to Integrate Muslims:** Struggled to unite Muslim masses for a unified nation.
 - **Urgent Power Transfer:** Needed to prevent communal violence and a failed Interim Government.
 - **Prevention of Balkanization:** Partition avoided fragmentation of princely states.
 - **Exhaustion and Failure to Control Riots:** Congress, fatigued and unable to manage riots, accepted partition as a solution.

Execution of Mountbatten Plan

- The Mountbatten plan was executed quickly, with legislative assemblies in Bengal and Punjab opting for Partition, resulting in:
 - **Partition Outcomes:** East Bengal and West Punjab became part of **Pakistan**, while West Bengal and East Punjab remained with **India**.
 - **Referendum in Sylhet:** A referendum in Sylhet led to its incorporation into **East Bengal**.
 - **Boundary Commissions:** Two commissions were established to delineate the new borders, culminating in the publication of the **Radcliffe Line** on **August 17, 1947**, which outlined the demarcation between India and Pakistan.
- **Dickie Bird Plan:** Before the final Mountbatten Plan, a proposal known as the "**Dickie Bird Plan**" was introduced. It suggested that provinces should become independent successor states instead of forming an Indian Union or two dominions. **Nehru** rejected this plan, warning it could lead to the **Balkanization** of India and provoke conflict, resulting in its cancellation.
- **Sir Cyril Radcliffe Commission (UPSC 2014):** Following the decision to partition India, the British established the **Sir Cyril Radcliffe Commission** in **July 1947**. This commission was tasked with demarcating

the boundaries between the newly formed dominions of **India** and **Pakistan**, particularly in Punjab and Bengal.

- **Note:** A delay in announcing the **Boundary Commission Award**, prepared by **Radcliffe**, which was ready by **August 12, 1947**, was intentional. Mountbatten chose to reveal it after **August 15**, thus absolving the British of responsibility for subsequent disturbances.

Indian Independence Act, 1947

- On **July 18, 1947**, the **Indian Independence Act**, based on the **Mountbatten Plan**, received royal assent after being passed by the **British Parliament** on **July 5, 1947**. Key provisions included:
 - Creation of two independent dominions, **India** and **Pakistan**, effective from **August 15, 1947**.
 - Each dominion would have a **Governor-General** responsible for implementing the Act.
 - Constituent assemblies would exercise legislative powers, resulting in the dissolution of the existing **Central Legislative Assembly** and **Council of States**.
 - Governments operated under the **Government of India Act, 1935**, until new constitutions were adopted.
 - Consequently, **Pakistan** gained independence on **August 14**, while **India** celebrated its freedom on **August 15, 1947**. **M.A. Jinnah** became the first **Governor-General** of Pakistan, and **Lord Mountbatten** continued as the **Governor-General** of India at India's request.

Integration of States

- **State People's Movement (1946-47)** surge for political rights and representation in **Constituent Assembly**. **Nehru** chaired **All India State People's Conference** in **Udaipur (1945)** and **Gwalior (April 1947)**, stating non-participating states would be treated as hostile.
 - **Phase I - Instrument of Accession:** By **August 15, 1947**, all states except **Kashmir**, **Hyderabad**, and **Junagadh** signed, granting central control over **defence**, **external affairs**, and **communication**.
 - **Phase II - Integration:** Complex integration into **Kathiawar**, **Vindhya**, **Madhya Pradesh**, **Rajasthan**, and **Himachal Pradesh**. **Hyderabad**, **Mysore**, and **Travancore-Cochin** retained boundaries. **Privy purses** offered; some princes became **Governors** or **Rajpramukhs**.

EVOLUTION OF THE TWO-NATION THEORY

- **1887:** Dufferin and Colvin's anti-Congress strategies included leveraging figures like **Syed Ahmed Khan** to discourage Muslim participation in the Congress, despite some Muslims joining.
- **1906:** The **Shimla Delegation**, led by **Agha Khan**, demanded **separate electorates** for Muslims, leading to the formation of the **All India Muslim League** to support **British loyalty**.
- **1909:** The **Morley-Minto Reforms** granted separate electorates, strengthening communal identities.
- **1915:** The first **All India Hindu Mahasabha** session marked organised Hindu political mobilisation.
- **1912-1924:** The **Muslim League** experienced internal shifts, increasingly adopting a **communal perspective**.
- **1916:** Congress's acceptance of separate electorates for Muslims signified political validation of the **Muslim League**.
- **1920-22:** Muslim involvement in movements like the **Khilafat** continued, but communal elements persisted in their political outlook.
- **1920s:** Communal riots escalated, with reactions from both communities, exemplified by the **Arya Samajists' Shuddhi movement** and Muslim counteractions.
- **1928:** The **Nehru Report** faced backlash from Muslim leaders, leading to **Jinnah's fourteen points**, which intensified communal demands.
- **1930-34:** Limited Muslim participation in the **Civil Disobedience Movement** highlighted divides within nationalist movements.
- **1932:** The **Communal Award** legitimised separate communal demands for Muslims.
- **Post-1937:** The **Muslim League** embraced extreme communalism, influenced by figures like **Rahmat Ali** and **Iqbal**, asserting Muslims as a **separate nation**.
- **March 24, 1940:** The **Lahore Resolution** called for independent states for Muslims in contiguous regions, crystallising the two-nation theory.
- **World War II:** The **British government** gave the League significant power, allowing it to press for a separate **Pakistan**, which was ultimately achieved in **1947**.

